



**Christopher
DeCou**

Curriculum Vitae

Contact

Email: cdecou@umich.edu

Phone: 734-492-2599

ORCID: 0009-0001-2593-434X

Website: christopherdecou.com

Education

- 2020 - 2026** **University of Michigan, PhD**
Dissertation: “The Stars in Their Eyes: Infrastructure and Tools of Everyday Knowledge in the Qing Empire, 1700-1900”
Advisors: Yi-Li Wu, Henry Cowles, Pär Cassel, Silvia Lindtner, Sarah Schechner (Harvard Collection of Scientific Instruments)
- 2012 - 2013** **University of Chicago, MA**
Thesis: “Aristotle in China: Chinese Aristotelian Translations during the mid-seventeenth century”
- 2008 - 2011** **University of Michigan, BA**
Majors: Asian Studies, Chinese
Medieval and Early Modern Studies

Employment

- 2026 - Present** **Friedrich-Alexander University (Erlangen–Nuremberg, Germany)**
Postdoctoral position
- 2020 - 2026** **University of Michigan (Ann Arbor, MI)**
Graduate Student Instructor
Research Assistant
Course Design
Grant Writing
- 2024** **University of Michigan, Inclusive History Project**
Research Assistant, Projects and Publications,
<https://historyofum.umich.edu/search/>
Content Writer
- 2019 - 2020** **Walworth Barbour American International School (Even Yehuda, Israel)**
Social Studies Instructor
- 2019** **Heller High School (Jerusalem, Israel)**
Social Studies Instructor
- 2018 - 2020** **Self-Employed (Remote)**
Freelance Science and History Writer
- 2013 - 2017** **Bugil Academy Global Leader Program (Cheonan, South Korea)**
Social Studies Instructor

Publications: Peer-Reviewed

Under review “The Scientific Instruments of Jiang Lintai and His Patrons in Late Imperial China,” *Nuncius: Journal of the Material and Visual History of Science*

Publications: Book Reviews

Forthcoming Review of *The Great Reversal: Britain, China and the 400-Year Contest for Power*, by Kerry Brown, H-Net Reviews, coming soon

Jul 2026 Review of *Observing the Unseen: Curiosity and Common Knowledge in Early Modern China*, by Andrew Schonebaum, H-Net Reviews, <https://www.h-net.org/reviews/showrev.php?id=62991>

Feb 2026 Review of *Body Maps: Improvising Meridians and Nerves in Global Chinese Medicine*, by Lan A. Li, H-Net Reviews, <https://www.h-net.org/reviews/showrev.php?id=62551>

Publications: Public History

Jan 2021 “Journey to the East”, *China Channel*, <https://chinachannel.lareviewofbooks.org/2021/01/08/tibet/>

Nov 2019 “The ancient doctors who refused payment”, *Wellcome Collection*, https://wellcomecollection.org/stories/Xc6-2REAAcGABY_t

Oct 2019 “Who Was Tank Kee?”, *Contingent Magazine*, <https://contingentmagazine.org/2019/10/28/tank-kee/>

Sep 2019 “Woodblocks in Wonderland: The Japanese Fairy Tale Series”, *The Public Domain Review*, <https://publicdomainreview.org/essay/woodblocks-in-wonderland-the-japanese-fairy-tale-series/>

Sep 2019 “The Hidden Professional Code Breakers of Renaissance Venice”, *Atlas Obscura*, <https://www.atlasobscura.com/articles/cryptography-renaissance-venice>

Aug 2019 “The Mystery of the 19th-Century Cotton Samples,” *Slate*, <https://slate.com/technology/2019/08/science-industry-museum-cotton-sample-s-barbour-brothers.html>

Jun 2019 “Bovine Inoculations, circa 1870s,” *The Scientist Magazine*, <https://www.the-scientist.com/bovine-inoculations--circa-1870s-65915>

Mar 2019 “Grim Relics”, *Knowable Magazine: The Magazine of the Annual Reviews*, <https://knowablemagazine.org/content/article/society/2019/grim-relics>

Feb 2019 “The Long History of the Mind-Bending ‘Tiny Planet’ Panorama,” *Atlas Obscura*, <https://www.atlasobscura.com/articles/the-history-of-tinyplanet-and-panoramas>

Jan 2019 “Illuminated Manuscripts Demonstrate that Medieval Borders Were Regularly Crossed”, *Hyperallergic*, <https://hyperallergic.com/478787/illuminated-manuscripts-demonstrate-that-medieval-borders-were-regularly-crossed/>

Jan 2019 “Oasis State: Kashgaria and the British Great Game”, China

	Channel, https://www.chinachannel.larbpublishingworkshop.org/2019/01/03/yaqub-beg/
Dec 2018	"The Dog Who Took the Witness Stand," <i>Narratively</i> , https://www.narratively.com/p/the-dog-who-took-the-witness-stand
Oct 2018	"When Whales Were Fish", <i>Lateral Magazine</i> , Issue 29, https://web.archive.org/web/20230216115755/https://www.lateralmag.com/articles/issue-29/when-whales-were-fish
Oct 2018	"Tank Kee's Library," <i>Lapham's Quarterly</i> , https://www.laphamsquarterly.org/roundtable/tank-kees-library

Digital Humanities Projects

2024	"Chinese celestial globe", The Things They Carried Digital Exhibition, Contributor for the Digital Exhibition, https://circex.ca/s/home/item/100
2020 - 2021	"Music Time in Africa", Reverb Effect, University of Michigan History Department, https://digitalscholarship.umich.edu/lisa-history/showcase/season-3-episode-1-music-time-in-africa/
2020 - 2021	Networked and mapped database of letters, individuals, and places in the Chidu xinchao, University of Michigan
2020	"Animal Traces through Image Classification of Historical Photographs in Google Cloud Vision: Case Study of World War I Photographic Collections", project employed computer vision and big data from Europeana to test object detection as a method for analyzing large datasets of historical photographs, University of Michigan

Conference Presentations

Jan 2026	"Instruments Beyond Books: Collecting and Trading Astronomical and Mathematical Instruments in Private Studios and Libraries in Early Nineteenth Century Imperial China", Beyond Books: Instruments and Knowledge in Libraries, Musée d'histoire des sciences, Geneva, 14-15 January 2026
Jun 2025	"Training Astronomers: Making Sundial Templates in the Practice of Astronomy in late imperial China", Sixteenth Biannual Notre Dame History of Astronomy Workshop, Notre Dame University, Notre Dame, June 11, 2025
Aug 2024	"Science Revolves: Qi Yanhuai and his Clockwork Celestial Globes", Global Astronomy Panel, Circulating Knowledge: 20 Years On Conference, Halifax, Ontario, Canada, Aug 9, 2024
Aug 2024	"Chinese Clockwork Celestial Globes", invited talk for "Things They Carried" Exhibition, Circulating Knowledge: 20 Years On Conference, Halifax, Ontario, Canada, Aug 7, 2024

Workshop Presentations

Jan 2025	"Time and a Very Small Place in Mongolia" invited presentation for graduate workshop "Reframing Global Connections and Encounters", Eisenberg Institute, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor, January 31, 2025
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Jan 2023	“Tackling Fish in the Mongol Empires: Consumption, Ecology, and Northern Exchange” invited presentation for graduate workshop, Lieberthal-Rogel Center for Chinese Studies, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor, January 30, 2023
Oct 2022	“Fish in the Mongol Empire”, prepared paper for graduate workshop Eurasia Collective: Rackham Interdisciplinary Graduate Workshop, University of Michigan, October 20, 2022
Oct 2020	“Korean Diplomatic Accounts of Qianlong Court Food Culture”, prepared translations for Qing Food Workshop, University of Michigan and University of Minnesota, October 19, 2020
Jun 2013	“Translating Aristotelian Meteorology in Late Imperial China”, invited presentation for Knowledge Making Workshop, University of Chicago, June 6, 2013

Courses Taught

- Humanizing Science: Writing in the Sciences (GSI)
- History of the Economy (GSI)
- History of Pre-Modern East Asia (GSI)
- History of Modern East Asia (GSI)
- History of Modern China (GSI)
- AP Research (Primary Instructor)
- AP European History (Primary Instructor)
- AP US History (Primary Instructor)
- AP World History (Primary Instructor)
- AP Comparative Government (Primary Instructor)
- American Government (Primary Instructor)
- Comparative Religion (Primary Instructor)
- Senior Project/Directed Research (Primary Instructor)

Professional Service & Associations

2024 - 2025	American Center for Mongolian Studies
2021 - 2023	Graduate Council, Radio Preservation Task Force, Library of Congress, Washington D.C.
2020 - 2022	Member, Graduate Editorial Board, Reverb Effect Podcast, Department of History, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor
2020	American Historical Association

Grants & Fellowships

May 2024	Summer Research Grant, Center for Russian, East European and European Studies, University of Michigan, \$2,500
May 2024	American Center for Mongolian Studies Field Research Grant (declined), \$1,000
Jan - May 2024	History Department Candidacy Fellowship, University of Michigan, \$12,990
Feb 2024	Rackham Graduate Student Candidate Research Grant, University of Michigan, \$3,000
Jul 2023	Rackham Graduate Student Precandidate Research Grant, University of Michigan, \$1,500

Sep - May 2023	Foreign Language Area Studies Fellowship (Academic Year) for the study of Mongolian, US Department of Education, \$20,000 + tuition
Jun - Aug 2023	Foreign Language Area Studies Fellowship (Summer) for the study of Mongolian, US Department of Education, \$5,000 + tuition

Honors & Awards

Jun 2025	Adler-Mansfield Graduate Presentation Prize, Adler Planetarium and History of Astronomy Workshop, \$2,000 + paid research trip at Adler Planetarium
Mar 2025	Phi Kappa Phi Honors Society
May 2024	Rackham International Research Award, University of Michigan, \$4,500
Jan 2024	Sydney Fine Outstanding GSI Award, University of Michigan, History Department, \$1,000
2020 - 2025	Lieberthal-Rogel Center for Chinese Studies Doctoral Fellowship, University of Michigan, \$5,000
2012 - 2013	Tuition Scholarship, MA Program in the Humanities, University of Chicago
May 2011	Summa Cum Laude in Asian Studies & MEMS, University of Michigan
May 2011	Goldstein Honors Prize, Robert Hayden Humanities Award, University of Michigan, Honors Program
May 2011	Charles O. Hucker Prize, University of Michigan, Department of Asian Languages and Cultures
May 2011	MEMS Thesis Award, University of Michigan, Department of Medieval and Early Modern Studies
2010 - 2011	James B. Angell Scholar, University of Michigan

Languages

Research	Classical Chinese & Mandarin (Advanced Reading) Mongolian & Classical Mongolian (Intermediate) French (Advanced Reading)
Additional	Spanish (Intermediate/Advanced) Korean (Reading)

Digital Skills

OS	Microsoft, Apple, Linux
Software	Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator, Microsoft Office, Google Suite, ArcGIS, QGIS, GeoDa, Slack, WordPress, Omeka, Jupyter, Google Cloud
Packages	Pandas, Numpy, PyTesseract, OpenCV
Programming	Python, R, HTML, SQL